

CM'S BOUNTY
Madhya Pradesh CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan distributing building permission certificates on May 23

MADHYA PRADESH

REGULARISING THE IRREGULAR

The BJP government's gift hamper comes as a relief for over 2 million people who have invested in unauthorised colonies, for it will now enable them to avail of loans and other government schemes for their properties. Urban planners, however, are concerned, and point out that such steps can jeopardise the development of urban spaces, especially in cities like Indore, which at 622 has the largest number of unauthorised colonies in the state, and in Bhopal and Jabalpur, with 238 and 224 such colonies, respectively. Unregulated dwellings have mushroomed in urban spaces as demand for affordable housing rises, with hundreds of thousands people migrating to cities in search of jobs and a burgeoning middle class aspiring to become homeowners. In Bhopal, for instance, many such colonies have come up around the Upper Lake in the western part of the city, the main source of drinking water for about 40 per cent of its residents. A large part of that area is agricultural land on the outskirts, which may face ecological disruption as unregulated settlements expand. "Unauthorised colonies are not factored into the city's development plan. If, say, there is a plan to shift hazardous industries to one corner of the city, and there is already such a colony there, it will be detrimental to its own safety," says an official from the state department of town and country planning, who wished to remain anonymous.

OVER 6,000 COLONIES THAT CAME UP WITH NO CLEARANCES WILL BE REGULARISED IN MADHYA PRADESH AHEAD OF THE ASSEMBLY ELECTION

This is not the first time unauthorised dwellings have been regularised en masse in Madhya Pradesh. It has been a recurring pitch in past polls, though with assurances each time that action will be taken to stem their growth. In fact, in June 2019, a division bench of the Madhya Pradesh High Court put brakes on the authorisation of nearly 4,000 colonies announced by the Chouhan government the previous year, terming the move 'illegal'. However, the government amended relevant sections of the Madhya Pradesh Municipalities Act, 1956 and 1961, and framed new rules. Soon, the Madhya Pradesh Nagarpalika (Colony Development) Rules, 2021, were notified, which enabled the government to restart the process of regularisation. Does the announcement mean developers of unauthorised colonies will be let off the hook? Says state urban development and housing minister Bhupendra Singh, "Our effort is to help those who have bought plots. Cases against developers who set up such colonies will not be withdrawn."

Several factors have contributed to the growth of unauthorised colonies in Madhya Pradesh. Given the lack of action by civic authorities, developers manage to find loopholes and circumvent rules. Plot prices in such colonies are often a tenth of those in regular ones, and given the ever-likely prospect of regularisation, buyers see them as excellent deals. The converse is equally true: law-abiding developers and citizens who buy plots in regular colonies at much higher prices eventually end up feeling cheated.